



WRITTEN BY ANDERSON · RECOUNTED BY JAY

Jay,

You're going to read this and think I've finally gone round the bend, and maybe I have, but hear me out before you write back with your usual line about me having "found Jesus in a jungle." I've been here four months now. I want to tell you what a day actually looks like, because I don't think you've believed a word I've said since I left, and I understand why. You watched me leave Blackpool with two duffel bags and a camera, and you've watched enough of my documentaries to know I get excited about things that don't pan out. This is different. I need you to know that before I say anything else.

I woke this morning to a sound I still haven't gotten used to — not traffic, not sirens, not the bloke downstairs from your flat who slams his door at half six. Birdsong, and under it, impossibly, silence. No hum of anything electrical, no distant road noise, nothing. I lay there for a minute just listening to nothing happening, which felt like an odd thing to miss until I realised how long it had been since I'd had it. They tell me the air out here tests properly oxygen-rich — something about the altitude and the tree cover working together — and the water comes straight off the mountain, no fluoride, no chlorine, nothing added because nothing needs to be. I didn't believe any of that mattered until I noticed I'd stopped getting the headaches I used to get most Sundays back home, the ones I always blamed on the pints. Turns out it might've been the tap water all along, mate. There's a village half an hour's walk from here, barefoot most days if you don't mind the trail, where they keep bees and sell the most extraordinary honey you've ever put in your mouth. I go for the walk as much as the honey now.

My place is one of three home styles here, and mine's what they call a barrel-vault — long and low, curved like something you'd expect to find half-buried on a desert planet in a film you and I used to watch as kids, rather than a house a grown man actually lives in. There's a dome-style further up the ridge that looks like it wandered out of a hobbit's dream, round windows and all, and then there's the mushroom houses — you'll meet one of those properly in a bit. All of it built from the ground it sits on, earth packed into bags and shaped until it looks grown rather than built. Above the main hall, carved into a roundel of local wood, there's a symbol everyone here just calls the Aetheon Equilibrius — two arcs balanced across a single point, meant to mean heaven in balance, David told me once, and nobody's ever explained it much further than that, which somehow suits the place. I still stop most mornings just to look at both.

I've got my acre same as everyone here — twelve of us hold seats on the council, and each one comes with land enough to do whatever you like with it. Some people garden. Some just let it go wild. Some have built things I still don't have names for. I mostly use mine to think, if I'm honest, and to walk Neo, who I should explain, because Neo is possibly the most important individual in this entire community and he isn't even a person.

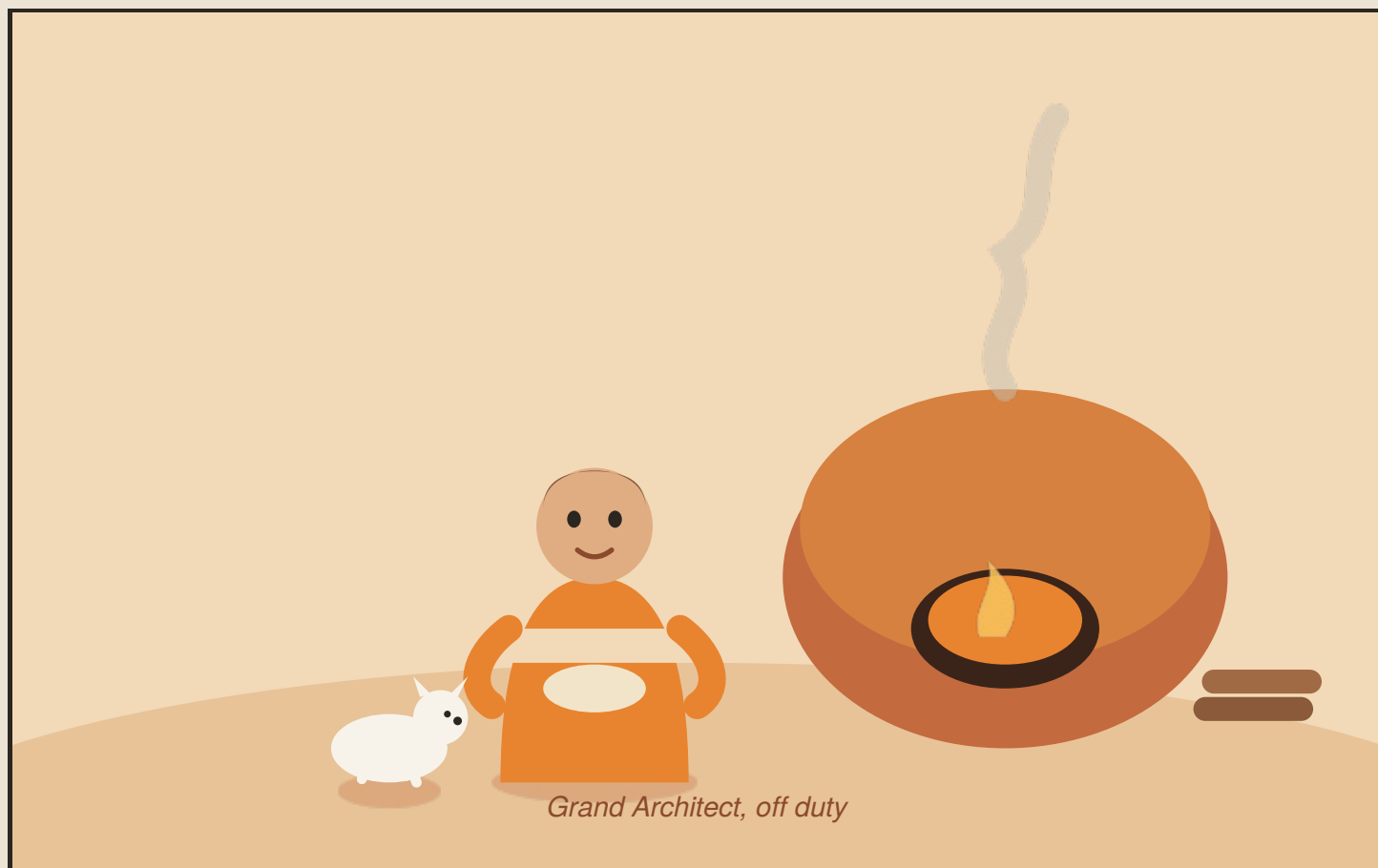
You'll laugh at this next bit, or you won't. I think about that flat you're in, the damp patch over the kitchen window neither of us ever got the landlord to sort, the walk past the arcade that's been boarded up since we were teenagers. I think about how neither of us used to flinch at any of it because we'd stopped noticing, the way you stop noticing a smell you live inside long enough. I didn't realise how much I'd stopped noticing until I got somewhere quiet enough to notice again. That's not me having a go at you, or at home. It's just the honest shape of what changed in me, and I owe you that.

Neo's a Scottish terrier, white as chalk, belongs to David — that's our director, more on him shortly — and I swear the dog runs this place more than the charter does. He turned up at my door this morning like he does most mornings, sat there wagging until I got the message, and off we went. I've started letting him lead. Four months in, I've learned that's usually the better plan.

I'll admit, mate, some mornings I still miss me mum something rotten, and there's no fixing that from here, not properly. But I know this was worth the journey, even on the mornings the missing catches me off guard.

He took me first toward the smoke on the ridge, the way he always does, up to the hut they call the Spirit House, where an old Australian named Max keeps a fire that's never once gone out. I'll tell you about Max properly later, Jay — properly, at length, because something happened up there today that I'm still turning over, and it deserves the ending of this letter, not a rushed mention at the start of it. For now I'll just say he was there, same as ever, and something about the way he looked at me this morning told me the conversation we'd eventually have wasn't going to be an ordinary one. I left him tending his coals and went on with my day, and I'll come back to him. Trust

me on that.



GRAND ARCHITECT, OFF DUTY

Neo led me down from there, tail up, straight toward the smell of woodsmoke and dough, which meant only one thing — David was at the pizza oven again. Clay-built, wood-fired, tucked behind the main hall, and our director, the man whose signature quite literally shapes what this whole community builds and votes on, was elbow-deep in flour looking thoroughly unbothered by the weight of his own job title.

"Working hard, Grand Architect of the Universe?" I said, because I couldn't help myself.

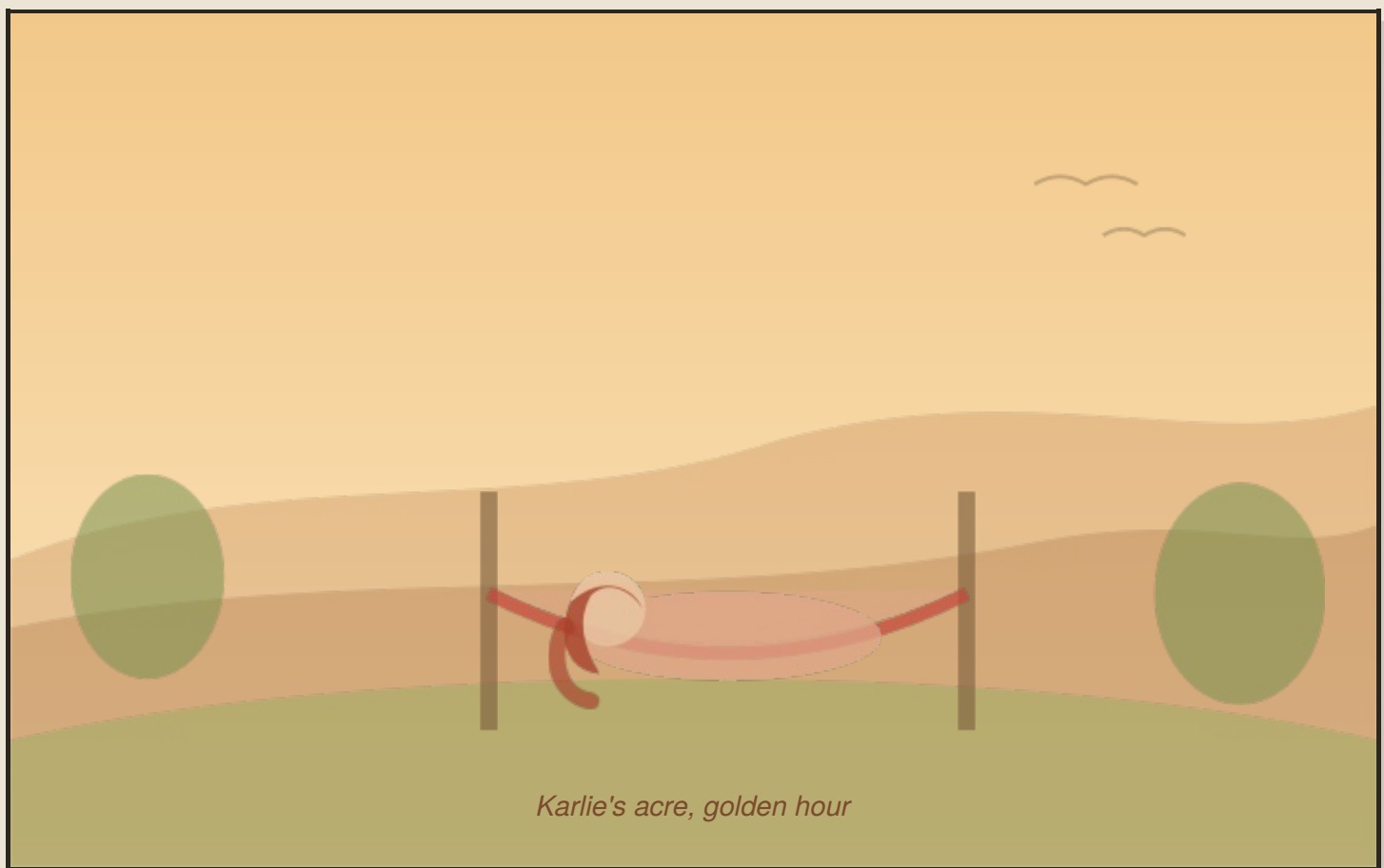
He didn't even look up. "Always have been. Mind the dough, it's rising." Completely straight-faced. That's David for you — the man could veto a proposal one hour and be flipping a margherita the next, and somehow both feel like the same job to him.

Karen found us there, unsurprisingly, because Karen finds everyone eventually. New Zealander, late sixties, rides a motorcycle everywhere because our one shared vehicle has broken down again, which she reminded David of at some length while he tried to focus on his crust. She runs our food deliveries from town and keeps closer track of everyone's ten hours than I suspect any of us would like, two cats named Sugar and Spice waiting for her at home and absolutely no patience for anyone who thinks the weekly obligation is optional.

"We need a mechanic," she told David, not for the first time, I gathered. "I am not learning to fix that engine myself, and I'm certainly not doing it on top of my own ten hours."

I mention it, Jay, only because you're going to want to remember that sentence by the time you finish reading this.

There's a wishing well near the main hall too, built the same season I arrived, bricks mortared in with each founding member's name scratched into the clay before it fired. I found mine straight off. Strange thing, seeing your own name set into a wall on a mountain you'd never heard of two years ago.



Karlie's acre, golden hour

KARLIE BEAR

I found Karlie out on her acre afterward, white and yellow polka dot sundress, barefoot in the dirt with flour on her hands too, though hers was headed for bread rather than pizza. First thing she ever said to me, months back, was that I looked Chechen, dead serious, like she was confirming a fact rather than making an observation. "Everyone always says that," she told me when I looked confused. I still don't know if anyone actually has, or if she's just decided it's true and enjoys watching me not know what to do with it.

She's Polish — proper farm stock, she'll tell you herself, grew up watching her grandmother make everything from nothing because nothing was ever handed to either of them. She told me once about that grandmother, actually, properly, not just in passing. Left Poland with a single suitcase and a toddler on her hip and no English at all, on nothing but a conviction that staying put was the more dangerous choice, not the safer one. "Everyone thinks bravery is loud," Karlie said, kneading in a rhythm that never once broke while she talked. "It isn't. It's a woman with one suitcase deciding the unknown is survivable. I think about her constantly out here. I think this is the first properly brave thing I've done since her."

She's known as Karlie Bear around here — earned it, from what I can tell, the same week she moved a fallen tree off the shared path with her own hands rather than wait for the following week's building roster. She's a recovering diabetic, manages it fiercely and openly, no shame in it at all, and she's become the community's reiki practitioner and general keeper of anything to do with rhythm and cycles — she follows a thirteen-month lunar calendar rather than the standard one, and she'll talk your ear off, cheerfully, about syncing your body to the moon instead of a clock some office somewhere invented. "You don't feel it in a city," she told me. "Too much light, too much noise, your body forgets it's an animal. Out here you remember fast."

She's partly deaf, has been since she was young, and wears a pair of hearing aids so quietly advanced I didn't clock them as hearing aids at all until she told me — they stream music straight into her ears, and translate Spanish for her in real time when she's talking with the workers who come up from the village, no phone required, nothing plugged into anything. "I like that they're off-grid too," she said, tapping one, grinning. "Everything about me that matters runs independent now,"

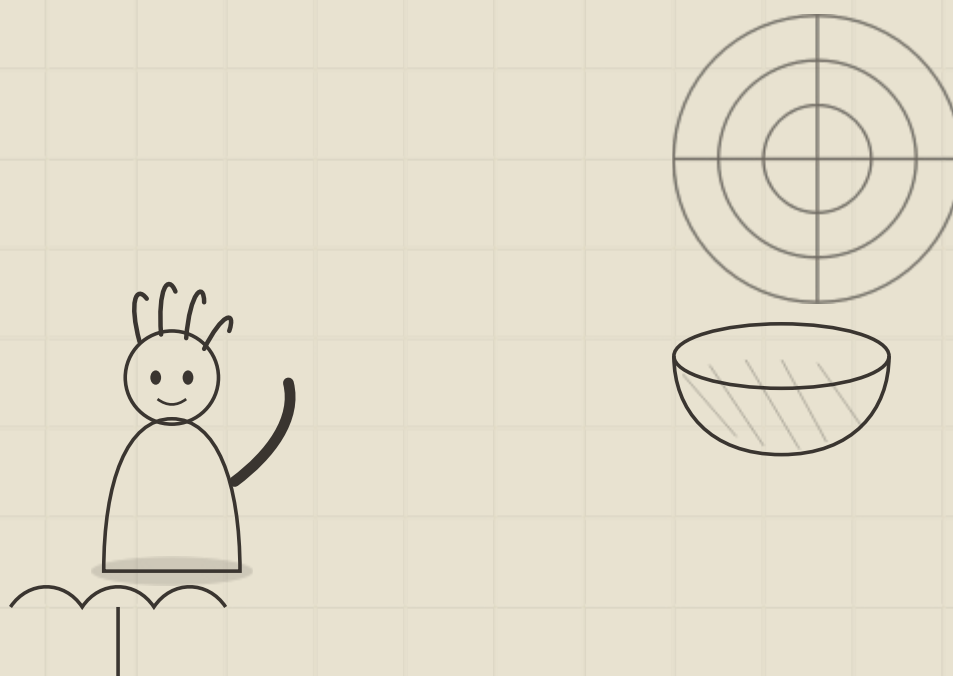
She runs our movie nights as well — proper old-school affair, a projector against the side of the barn, popcorn, the whole community sprawled out on blankets. Labyrinth is her favourite, every time, no contest, and she'll tell you David Bowie is the only real king this community secretly answers to, council or no council. She also throws a pierogi dinner most months that half the valley seems to know about by now, and teaches Spanish on the side, half slang she's picked up from me and half real vocabulary she's determined I'll actually learn this year.

"Oi, you muppet, that's not how you conjugate it," she told me today, laughing, after I'd butchered something simple, and went right back to her bread.

I asked her, since we were talking about grandmothers and bravery, whether she ever regretted it — leaving everything behind the way her grandmother had, the way she had herself, twice removed and still somehow carrying the same weight.

She thought about it properly before answering, which is rare for her, usually she's three jokes deep before you've finished the question. "Some days. Not the leaving. Never the leaving. Some days I miss the specific smell of my grandmother's kitchen in October, and no amount of good living out here replaces that, because it isn't about the place, it's about a woman who isn't here anymore." She wiped flour off her hands, looked out at the valley, the mountains going gold at the edges with the last of the light. "But I think she'd recognise this. The suitcase, the not knowing, the deciding anyway. I think if she saw me out here, barefoot, making bread with my own two hands on a mountain in the middle of nowhere, she wouldn't ask me why. She'd just nod, the way she used to, like it was obvious all along that this was where I'd end up. Some bravery skips a generation and lands twice as hard on the third."

I didn't have anything clever to say back to that, so I didn't try. Somewhere behind her a bird was going properly mad with song, and she didn't even glance at it, the way you stop hearing a thing that's simply always true. Nobody out here bothers with daylight savings either, incidentally — twice a year the rest of the world quietly rearranges its clocks and Elysian Wells just doesn't, and nobody's ever explained why that felt worth doing except that it does.



Field notes — cultivation & sound

Doc was next, and Doc is exactly what he sounds like — hair like he's just been struck by lightning, an American who talks faster than I can film. He runs what's growing on this land, which is most of it, honestly, and he's forever experimenting.

I found him crouched over a bed of seedlings with a coil of copper wire strung between two posts above them, humming faintly, and a Tibetan singing bowl balanced on an overturned crate beside him.

"Tell me this isn't doing anything," I said, "and I'll believe you, because I want to."

"I'll tell you what I told the skeptics back at the university before they stopped returning my calls." He struck the bowl once, let it ring itself out, and pointed at the seedlings like they'd just won an argument on his behalf. "Plants respond to vibration. Not mysticism — measurable, published, entirely boring science if you read the right journals instead of laughing at the wrong headlines. The coil's electroculture, passive current, encourages root uptake. The bowl's the bit nobody's proven yet, and I'll be the first to say so. I do it anyway. You know why?"

"Why?"

"Because I might be wrong about the how and still right about the why. Attention changes things, Anderson. Doesn't matter if it's a plant or a person." He grinned, wild-eyed and completely sincere. "Also the tomatoes this season are the best I've ever grown, and I'm not in the mood to rule anything out that's currently winning."

We got to talking properly after that, about the documentary, about where I want to take it next. Doc's read more about the old cultures of this part of the world than anyone else I've met out here — not just the ruins themselves, but the cosmology behind them, the way half a dozen ancient peoples across this whole stretch of the Americas kept arriving, independently, at the same handful of ideas.

"Every one of them's got a version of the same three things," he said, ticking them off on dirt-stained fingers. "A sacred mountain, standing in for the axis the whole world turns on. An underworld river you cross to get anywhere that matters. And a serpent that eats its own tail and starts the world over again. You find that shape from the high desert clear down through the jungle basins, cultures that never once met, and they all landed on the same picture independently. Either that's coincidence, or human beings are wired to notice the same pattern wherever you drop them."

"Which do you think it is?"

"Wired. Has to be. Give any two people a mountain, a river, and a long enough winter to think about dying, and they'll build you roughly the same myth, guaranteed. That's not ancient aliens, whatever the documentaries you're competing with want to tell you. It's evidence human beings are more alike under the myth than the myth ever lets on." He wiped his hands on his knees, delighted with himself. "Which is a much better story than the one where somebody had to come teach us."

We're properly planning a trip now, further out — the Galápagos first, if the timing works, since Doc's convinced there's something in the isolation of those islands, the way evolution ran its own separate experiment out there undisturbed, that rhymes with what he's trying to say about isolated cultures landing on the same ideas. Then across to see what's left standing at Puma Punku, those cut stones fitted so precisely nobody's fully explained the tooling. There's a stretch of coastline along the way Doc keeps calling "columnas de basalto" in his terrible Spanish, basalt columns, great hexagonal pillars of rock stacked like something poured rather than formed, and I want it filmed properly before anyone else beats me to it — specifically before a man named Dribble does, an old rival from a documentary festival years back, a salty bitch of a pseudo-archaeologist with small soft hands and a faint permanent smell of boiled cabbage, who's apparently sniffing round this exact coast for his next production. I'd rather eat my own camera than let him get there first.

Doc's taken to calling the pair of us Castro and Che on this trip, motorcycle diaries and all, and I told him that's a bit much for two men on a rented dirt bike with a GoPro, more Trudeau and Che if we're being honest about our combined revolutionary credentials, which made him laugh so hard he nearly dropped a seedling tray.

There's a fellow out by the coast, Ryan, Canadian, originally Edmonton, surfer, bit of a party animal, bought a property out there for forty-four thousand dollars American that we might stop by. And somewhere further into the jungle there's an American named Justin, twenty-two if he's a day, married into an indigenous family out

there, three wives, one with a new baby, runs a small channel about the life he's built. Word is he's assimilated so thoroughly he still can't manage to chop a tree down properly — his mother-in-law asked him to clear one, handed him a dull axe, and he's apparently never quite lived it down. We'd talked about detouring to see him, waterfalls along the way meant to be spectacular, but the storm's likely washed the road out, and he's off-grid enough that there's no ringing ahead to check.

I still don't understand half of what he explains to me. The tomatoes, though. The tomatoes I understood completely, and he sent me off with three of the ripest, plus half a dozen fresh eggs from the coop, plus a small paper bag of coffee beans he roasts himself on a converted drum over an open flame — the coffee here, incidentally, might be the best I've ever had, and it's growing thirty feet from where it's roasted. I ate one of the bananas off his lower field on the walk home, the little stubby sweet kind, and did the maths in my head without meaning to: back home that'd have cost the better part of a pound for one banana shipped halfway round the world. Here it cost nothing at all beyond the walk to go pick it.

There's a German fellow who turns up most months, naturalist by trade, English barely holding together but his conviction unmistakable, raising money online tree by tree to reforest a slope the valley lost decades back. Nobody quite knows how he found us, only that he keeps returning, muddy boots and a clipboard and more patience for saplings than most people have for anything. He showed me a photograph once, the slope as it used to be, thick and green, and then the same slope now, bare in patches like a bad haircut, and said only, "we fix," pointing at a row of thin new trunks he'd planted himself the previous spring, not one of them taller than my knee yet. I've started looking for him on my walks now, half hoping to catch him mid-plant so I can film it properly for the documentary — there's something in a man devoting himself entirely to trees he'll likely never see grown that feels like it belongs in whatever I end up making of all this.

There's a home too, further round the valley wall, built directly into the hillside like a proper cave, the owners and half the community trading labor back and forth on it for months — I still haven't worked out whose idea that one was, only that it's extraordinary, cool inside even at midday, and that everyone who helped build it seems to feel it's partly theirs now, the way you feel about anything you've bled a little sweat into.

I've got my good camera out most days chasing all of this, four K, drone besides, and I'll admit some pride in both — I've filmed things this year I'd never have gotten near back home, and some nights, camera pointed straight up, I've caught small orbs of light doing things fireflies don't do, dancing, hovering, gone before the footage means anything. Everyone's got a theory. Nobody's got a clean shot yet. I keep trying.



THE MUSHROOM HOUSE

Janette's was next on the loop, and Neo insisted, same as always. You have to see this place to believe it — from the outside it looks exactly like a mushroom grown to the size of a house, round and low and capped, and a little triangle window up in the loft that catches the last of the light every evening. Inside, it's all bamboo and stone and clay, sticks worked into the walls like the whole place was woven rather than built. She's Canadian, somewhere in her fifties, long chestnut hair, the kind of smile that makes you forget what you walked over to ask her.

"Try some," she said, same as she says every single time, holding out something home-grown I've turned down every single time. "Devil's lettuce, Anderson. Good for the soul."

"Maybe next year, Janette."

"You said that last year." She laughed, then got a familiar gleam in her eye, the one that means she's about to say something purely to watch my face. "You believe the earth's a spinning ball hurtling round the sun at ridiculous speed, don't you."

"Last I checked, yeah."

"Mm." She said it the way you'd humour a child who still believes in something sweet. "I've flown plenty. Never once seen a curve. Not once. And you'll notice — no contrails out here, either. None. That's not nothing, Anderson."

"Janette, I really don't think — "

"NASA," she said, cutting me off, delighted with herself, "stands for Never A Straight Answer. That's not even my line, that's an old one, but it's never once stopped being true."

"You genuinely believe it. The flat part."

"I genuinely believe I've never once seen proof of the round part, which isn't quite the same claim, but yes, close enough for your purposes." She settled onto her doorstep, warming to it properly now. "There's an ice wall,

supposedly, ringing the whole thing, Antarctica the way nobody's actually allowed to properly explore it anymore, funny that. And some of the older thinking says it isn't flat exactly so much as hollow, whole worlds tucked inside worlds, which I'll admit I find a prettier idea than either flat or round, if I'm honest, though I'll defend flat because it's the one that gets people properly annoyed at dinner."

"That's not really evidence, Janette."

"It's not meant to be evidence, love, it's meant to be a door left open. Most people go their whole lives never once questioning the shape of the actual ground beneath them, and I think that's a stranger way to live than mine is." She shrugged, entirely pleased with herself. "You know what I actually think matters, underneath all the fun of it? Nobody up here has told me to shut up in four years. Not once. That's the part that actually matters. This isn't a place that punishes a woman for thinking something odd. Wherever we actually are, this whole part of the world just doesn't care to police anyone's opinions the way home did, and I'd rather live somewhere that lets me be wrong out loud than somewhere that only lets me be correctly silent."

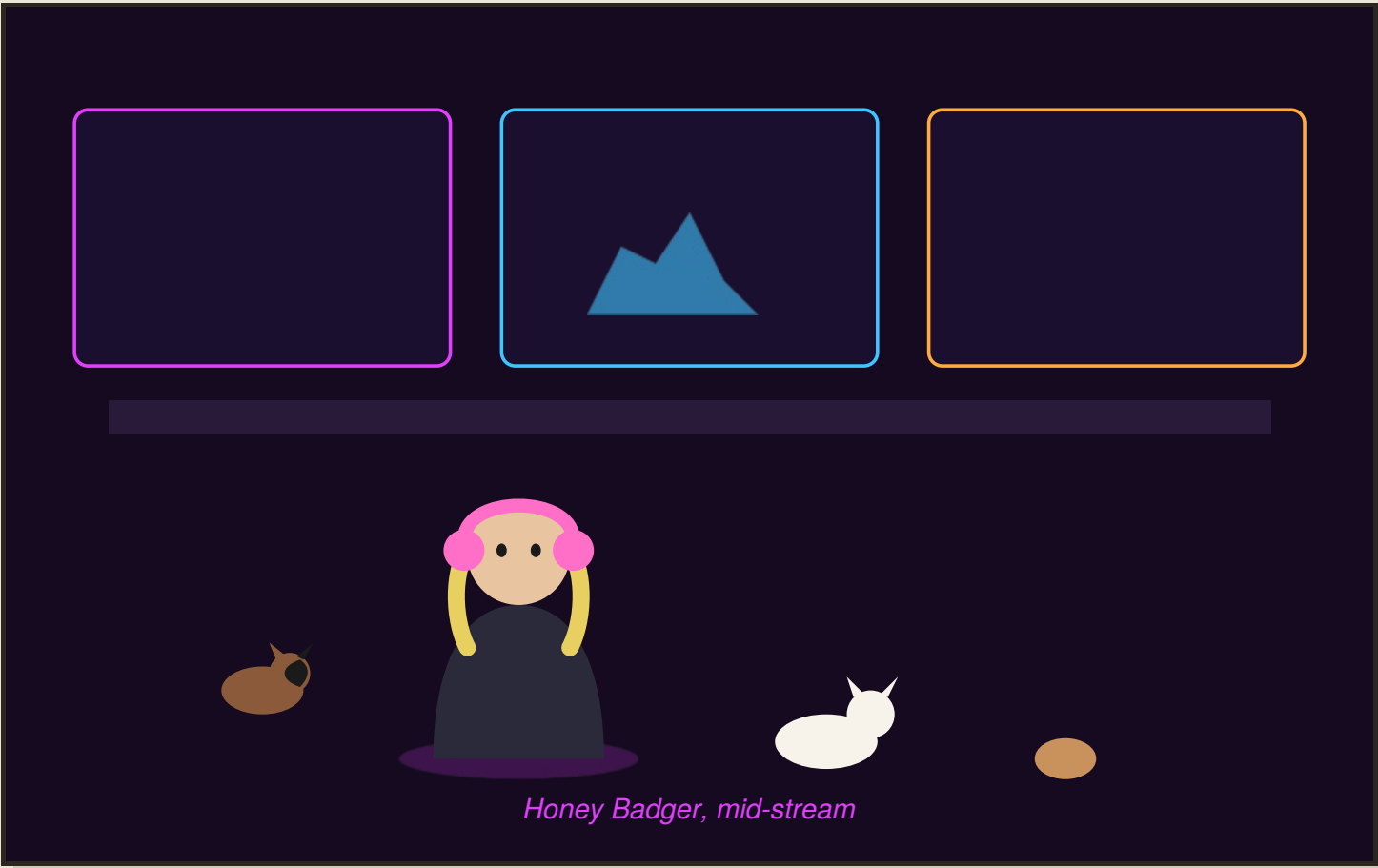
"That's fair, actually."

"I know it is. Once you go flat, Anderson, you don't go back." She grinned at her own joke longer than it probably deserved, and I let her have it, because she'd earned the delight fair and square.

I asked, because I couldn't help it, what she missed about home, expecting something sincere.

"Honestly? Giant Tiger," she said, without missing a beat. "Cheap socks and a hot dog for two dollars. I'll take the ice wall theory to my grave before I give up on missing that place."

I left laughing, which I think was the entire goal. You'll meet her properly yourself soon enough, I suspect — she'll sell you a small unlabelled bag off her porch for a price in Monero if you flash the right app, and throw in a jar of her own strawberry jam besides, no charge, like the two transactions live in entirely separate economies in her head. Knowing you, you'll take both.



I should tell you about Nova before you meet her properly, because nothing I say will prepare you and I want partial credit for trying.

Neo and I were on the trail loop behind the gardens when he went rigid, ears up, and took off after something small and fast with half its face black as pitch, like it was permanently hiding in its own shadow. That's Freya — Norwegian forest cat, brown-furred, belongs to Nova — and Freya, evidently unimpressed by the chase, bolted straight through an open door, Neo hot behind her, me hot behind him, all three of us crashing into what I can only describe as the loudest room in Elysian Wells.

Nova was mid-livestream. Fuzzy pink headphones the size of dinner plates, three monitors glowing, a controller in her hands and a horse mid-gallop across a screen behind her, and when Neo and Freya tore through the middle of her setup she didn't so much as glance at the chat.

"F*!" she said, entirely to the room, not the camera, swinging round in her chair as Freya launched herself onto a bookshelf and Neo skidded into a beanbag chair that exploded feathers everywhere. Somewhere underfoot, a guinea pig I hadn't even clocked yet — Lucy, I'd learn — made a valiant, doomed run for a dropped crust of bread.

"Sorry," I said, "he saw the cat and — "

"Don't apologise, this is the best thing that's happened on stream all week." She was already laughing, pulling the headphones down round her neck, chat presumably losing its mind in the background, entirely disregarded. Short, early thirties, hair in tight blond braids on a head slightly too large for the rest of her in a way that somehow made her more memorable rather than less. "You're the documentary guy. Anderson."

"Guilty."

"Nova. Some people call me Honey Badger, on account of the fact I do not give a single f* what anyone thinks and I will absolutely still get the thing done." She said it with visible pride. "Sit if you want. Mind the chaos. It's fairly constant."

I sat, cautiously, while Freya glared down from the bookshelf and Neo attempted, unsuccessfully, to look like he hadn't caused an international incident. Behind her, paused on one monitor, was unmistakably an anime — something with enormous eyes and an even more enormous sword — and on a second screen, a music program open mid-edit.

"You're scoring something?"

"Remixing something. I'm a Grimes fanatic, absolute disciple, Digital Calypso on repeat for about six years running now." She hummed a few bars, unselfconscious, actually rather good. "We should do karaoke one night. Whole community, terrible speakers, worse singing."

"Absolutely not," I said. "I'm British. We don't do that sort of joy in public."

"Coward," she said, entirely without malice, already moving on. "Labels wanted the sound, not the person attached to it. Contracts, ownership splits, some exec deciding what 'my' next single should sound like. I made more money the year I left than the year before I did, doing it entirely on my own terms, and I get to live in a place with limitless inspiration in a house I built with my own two hands."

"And the tech work? Karen mentioned you run the internet out here."

"Tech director. Project manager for anything that makes this place money beyond what any one of us earns privately. Somebody's gotta think about revenue that isn't personal income, or the whole beautiful hippie experiment starves. I do the numbers. I build the systems. People think artist and businesswoman are opposites and it's f*ing embarrassing how wrong that is."

"You call yourself an anarchist capitalist, I heard."

"I call myself a person who wants to build things and keep what she builds, and doesn't want a government or a label or a committee telling her how." She shrugged, entirely unbothered. "George Carlin used to say the game is rigged and you're not in it. I just went and built a different game."

Lucy the guinea pig had by now successfully commandeered the bread crust and was defending it from absolutely no one with tremendous conviction. Freya had not moved from the bookshelf. Neo had given up all pretense of dignity and was simply lying in the feathers, looking extremely pleased with himself.

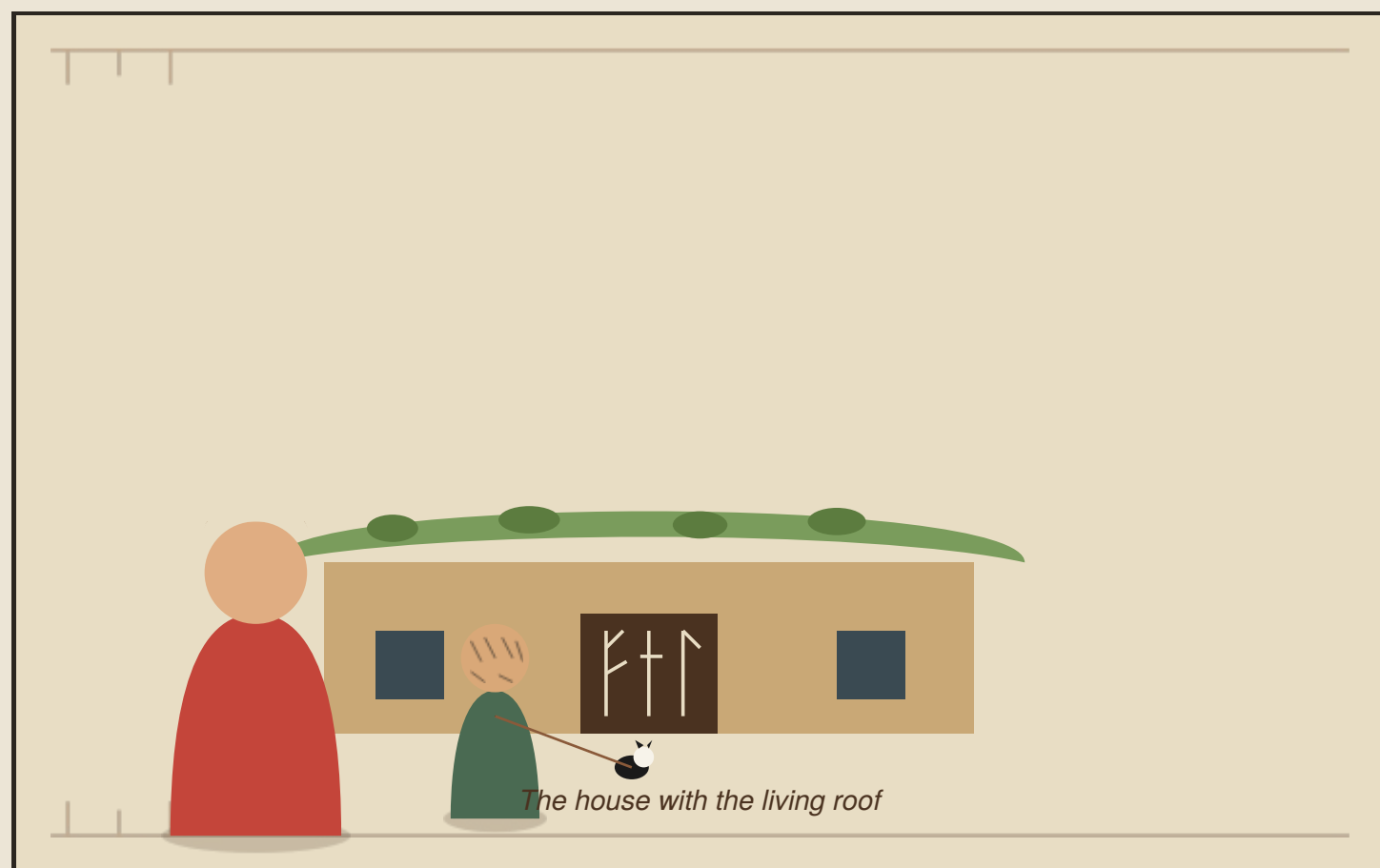
"You've got a good life out here," I said.

"I've got a free one. Different thing, most people don't clock the difference till they've had both." She grinned, already reaching back for her headphones, chat presumably still screaming. "Now get your dog off my beanbag before he owes me rent."

I teased her on the way out, couldn't help it, said she spends more time streaming than actually making anything these days. She didn't even look wounded by it.

"Streaming is the art, you muppet." She said it like I'd missed something obvious. "Everything I do is. The Muse doesn't clock in at nine, she just shows up whenever she fancies, and my job's just staying loose enough to notice when she has. Ask any exec who ever tried scheduling her." She keeps a proper apiary out back too, bees going, her own honey, a whole shelf of jars she's fiercely proud of. "Here, you can finally breathe and not have to live in some concrete jungle," she added, entirely sincere for once. "That's not nothing, Anderson. That's actually everything."

She's a devout Alex Grey fan, the artist who did all the old Tool covers, visionary stuff, and she'll tell you flatly that music hasn't been properly good since the nineties, that she still misses Blockbuster more than she'll ever miss a label meeting, cowgirl boots up on the desk while she says it like she's daring you to disagree.



ODIN, THE KITCHEN, AND A SMALL MAN FROM WINNIPEG

I was still laughing about that when I passed the strangest, loveliest house on the whole property — earthbag same as the rest, but with a living roof, actual grass and small flowers growing across the top of it, and carved wooden shapes worked into the door frame that took me a second look to recognise as runes. This is Nick and Tom's place, and I could smell breakfast from thirty feet away, because breakfast here, most mornings, is free, made to order, and entirely the work of these two men. ^x

A small black-and-white chihuahua came tearing round the corner of the house the second I got close, yapping with the full fury of something roughly the size of a shoe, and was scooped up almost instantly by Tom, who cradled her against his enormous chest like she was made of glass. "This is Odin," he said. "We keep her leashed outside, she's tiny enough a hawk could take her seriously, and we are not remotely embarrassed about how overprotective we are."

Tom, if I haven't properly described him yet, is enormous — ex-professional wrestler, built like something off a longship, and he'll tell you without any prompting that his old ring persona was a straight tribute act to the British Bulldog, Union Jack trunks and all, back before a wrestling injury tore something in his colon badly enough that he nearly didn't survive it. Twice. Twenty years an industrial insulator before all that, and he'll complain about scaffolding regulations at the drop of a hat, right up until you mention he retired at thirty-eight because he bought Bitcoin back when everyone thought that was a joke.

Nick was at the stove, eggs going, and he's small — five foot three, maybe less — Mexican on one side, Irish on the other, his face covered jaw to temple in tattoos I've mentioned before, dense runic symbols he never chose and didn't understand for years, inked into his skin one blackout night in Winnipeg by a stranger he never identified.

"He's a Canadian Navy veteran," Tom told me, plating eggs like it was the most natural fact in the world. "Served. Proper service, the kind that earns you a disability pension for the rest of your life, which is a good deal of how we live as comfortably as we do out here."

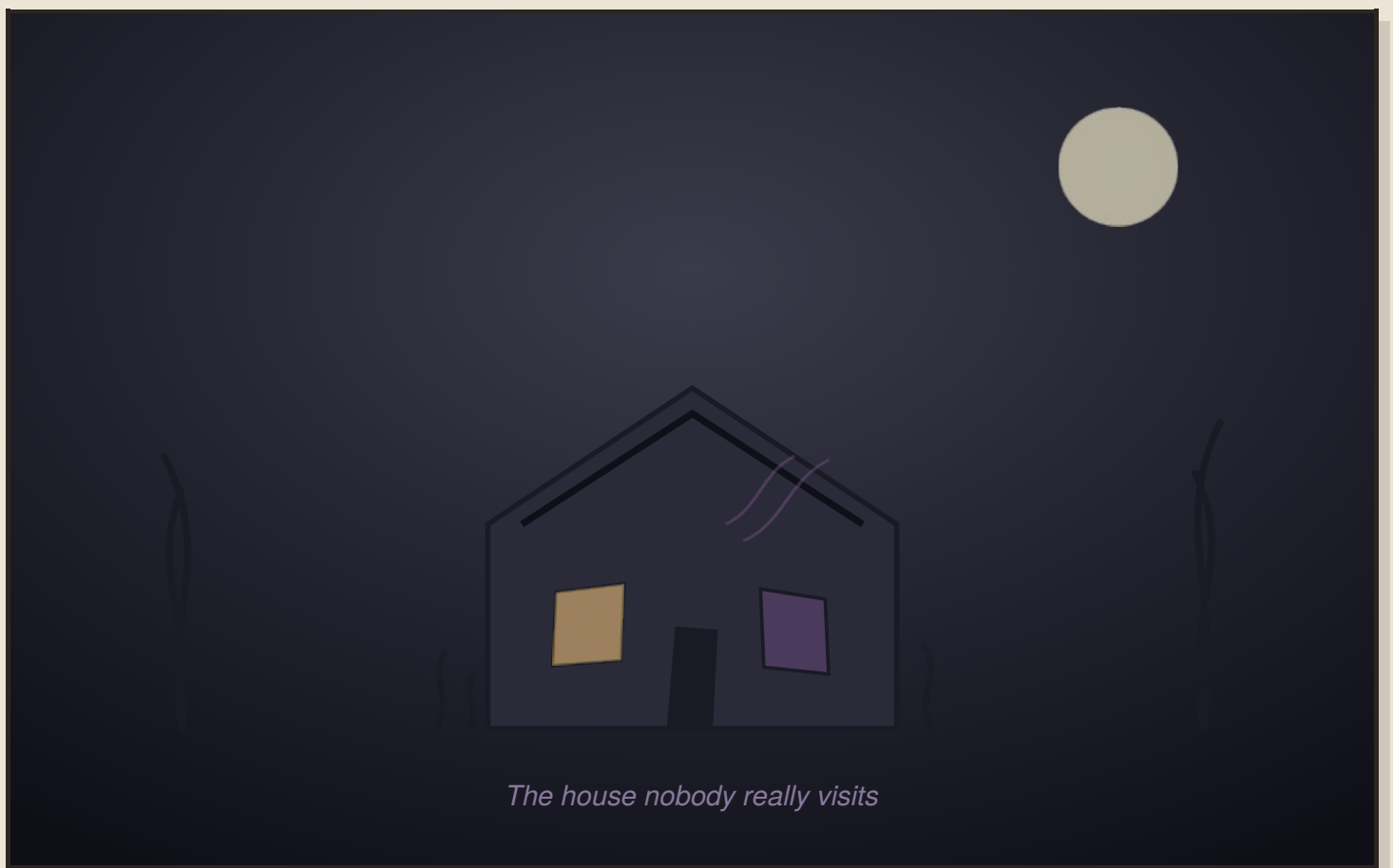
I'll be honest with you, Jay — I've heard a couple of people around here murmur, quietly, that they find that hard to square with the man himself, small as he is, tattooed the way he is, and I understand the instinct even if I don't share it. People built an image of what a veteran looks like a long time ago and Nick simply doesn't match the picture in their heads. That's on them, not him. Tom's never once wavered telling it, and Tom's not a man who lies about things that matter to him.

Nick doesn't speak much English — Spanish and Esperanto, that's it — and Tom translates, badly, on the Esperanto end especially, an old joke between them that never gets old. "He fell asleep at a party in Winnipeg," Tom said. "Blackout drunk. Woke up like this. Never found out who did it, and here's the part that gets me every time — it's not gibberish. Somebody who actually knew the old runes did this. Near as anyone's translated it, it says God is with them on this land. I'm pagan, mythology's basically my whole personality, and here's this man wearing a blessing he never asked for. I fell for him completely the day I finally translated it myself."

They travel together constantly when they're not cooking for the whole community — jungle one month, a beach the next, cities, old churches, camping whenever the mood takes them, horses booked for a ride along the ridge trail next week that I've already invited myself along to. "Whole month here costs us less than one week used to cost back home," Tom told me, plating eggs, "and that's including the horses."

Breakfast, most days, is entirely free to everyone here, ingredients straight off the farm, and dessert usually gets bartered rather than bought — someone's homemade chocolate made from cacao grown thirty feet from where it's melted, traded for an hour of someone else's skill rather than money changing hands at all. Nobody keeps a ledger on any of it, near as I can tell, beyond the Elysian Hour itself when something's substantial enough to warrant one.

"Come by for dinner sometime," Tom said as I left, sliding a plate my way I hadn't even asked for. "I do a smoked bacon that'll make you weep. Best in the world, and I'll fight anyone who says otherwise." He glanced back at the house, its living roof catching the last of the morning light, grass and small flowers thick across the top. "Built that roof ourselves, you know. Nick did the runic carving over the door himself, once he'd learned what his own face was trying to tell him."



THE HOUSE NOBODY REALLY VISITS

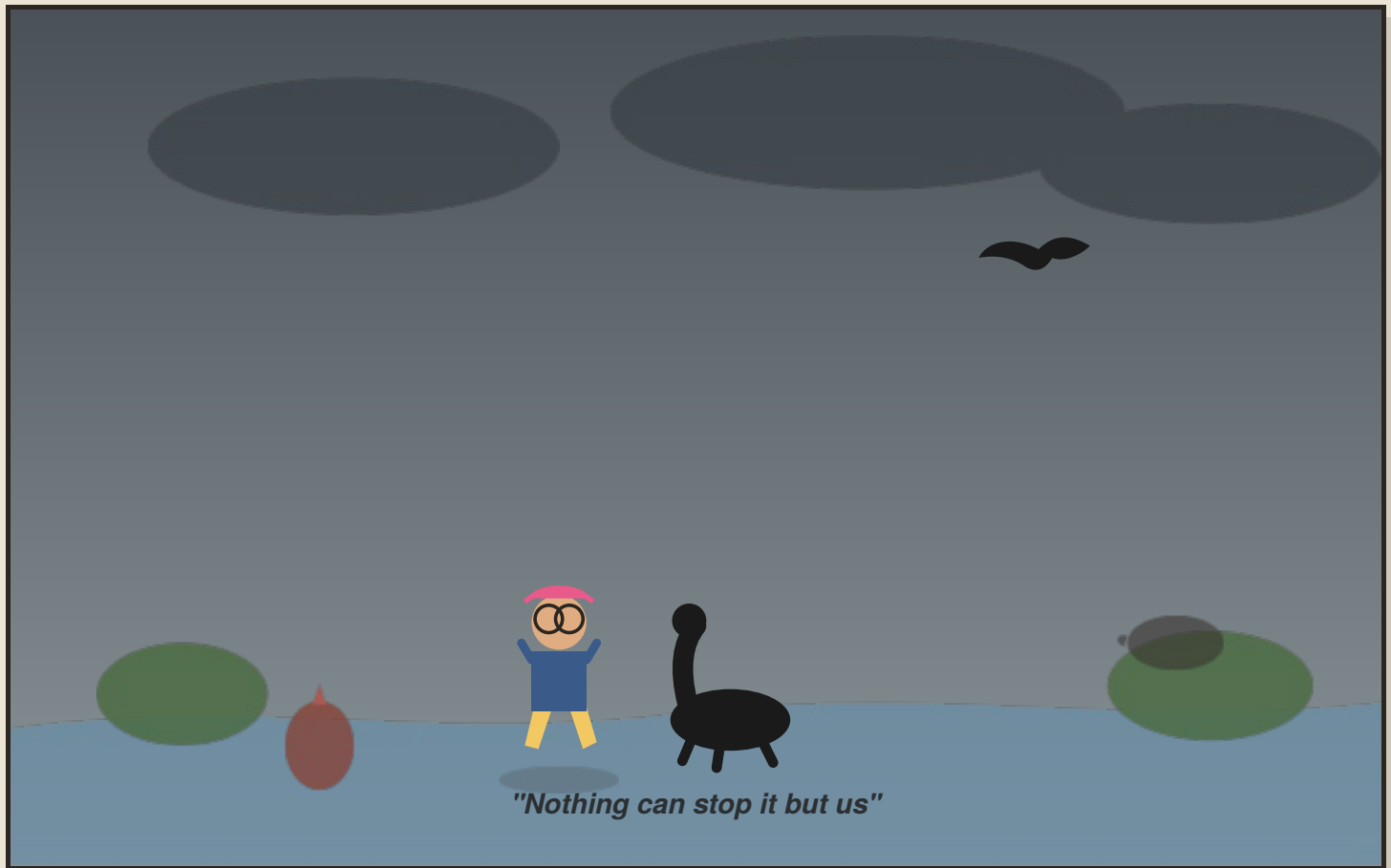
On my way back down, I passed a house I still don't fully understand — low, dark timber, oddly angled, gothic almost, like something out of a Tim Burton film, all crooked windows and a garden gone deliberately wild rather than tended, more Edward Scissorhands than earthbag sanctuary. Music was coming from inside, low and heavy, electric guitar, the kind of sound that doesn't belong on a quiet mountain at midday and somehow works anyway.

Nobody seems entirely sure of the man who lives there. Jay, I'm going to tell you what I've pieced together, and none of it may be fully true, because that's rather the point of him. His girlfriend's name is Clarissa — she has a proper following online, a podcast with real numbers behind it, and she holds a council seat in her own right. He doesn't. I think his name might be Robert, though I've genuinely never heard him say it himself and I'm not confident anyone else has either. Electrical engineer, apparently, deep into Tesla and free energy and, from what Doc's hinted at, some rather serious ideas about alchemy that aren't metaphors to him. Somebody mentioned, half-joking, that he might be Rosicrucian. Somebody else swears, entirely straight-faced, that he was taken by something not of this earth as a boy in what used to be Czechoslovakia, and has never fully come back the same.

I've never spoken to him. Not once, in four months. I've only ever passed the house, heard the guitar, and kept walking, which somehow feels like exactly the correct way to know him. Clarissa mentions him sometimes, briefly, fondly, the way you'd mention weather you'd long since stopped needing to explain to anyone — "he's tinkering," she'll say, or "he had one of his nights," and never elaborate further, and nobody ever asks her to. I did notice, once, a strange copper coil arrangement half-buried near his garden fence, wired to nothing visible, and chose, deliberately, not to ask what it was for. Some mysteries out here are clearly meant to stay exactly that.

TOP LOBSTER

I was thinking about that strange quiet house when Karen caught up with me on her motorcycle, idling alongside just long enough to shout that they'd gotten fresh lobster in from the coast — "top lobster," she called it, like it was a title rather than a delivery — and something dark passed low overhead the second she said it, quick enough that I only caught the shape of it: a raven, wide-winged, gone into the treeline before I could properly track it. I don't know why the two things happened together. I've stopped assuming things out here need a reason.



I was on my way back when the mantis found me again — same still, tilted watching I'd seen at the Spirit House more than once now, perched this time on a fence post along the trail. I stopped. It didn't move. And when I took a step toward it, it dropped off the post and into the undergrowth, unhurried, like it wanted following rather than fleeing. I still don't know what it is or isn't, Jay. I've stopped needing to.

I followed, down a narrow path along the river where the trees close in properly and the light goes green and filtered, and I lost the mantis almost immediately in the brush, the way you always do, and stood there feeling faintly ridiculous until I heard someone talking to a chicken with tremendous authority a little further on.

"You are a menace, Bruce, and everyone knows it," said a voice, "and if you peck me again I am telling David and he'll put you in a pizza."

I came round the bend to find a girl, maybe nine, giant round glasses too big for her face, hair in braids dyed some shade of pink that looked freshly done, blue suspenders, yellow boots, stomping cheerfully through a mud puddle while squaring off against the single largest rooster I have ever seen in my life. Bruce, presumably, stood very nearly four feet tall and regarded her with the flat, murderous patience of something that has never once lost an argument.

"You must be Lexi," I said. Nova's daughter, though nothing about the two of them looks alike beyond the sheer refusal to be intimidated by anything.

"I am, and you're the documentary man, and you missed the tapir." She said this with the specific devastation of a child reporting a genuine tragedy. "Mountain tapir. They're basically never right there. It had a little trunk thing and everything and it just looked at us for ages and then wandered off like it does this all the time, which I guess it does, it lives here."

She's homeschooled — unschooled, she corrected me immediately and with some force, there's a difference — by Nova and Max both, actually, I learned; Max apparently teaches all the community's children some mornings, Steiner-style, whatever that means to a nine-year-old, and Lexi seems to have absorbed something real from it, some habit of noticing the whole world rather than the ^{xiii}version of it that's useful.

"There's frogs though. Glass frogs, come here, look — " She crouched by the river's edge, utterly fearless, and pointed at something so small and pale I nearly missed it entirely. "You can see its heart. Actually see it. That's not a metaphor, its skin's basically see-through." I looked. She was right, and it was somehow more moving than it had any business being.

"Bats come out at dusk," she told me, already moving on, cataloguing the whole valley like she owned shares in it. "Fruit bats mostly, not scary, they just want the figs. There's an olinguito somewhere in these trees too, basically a tiny fluffy raccoon nobody even knew existed until like fifteen years ago." Something enormous and armored buzzed past my ear at that moment and I very nearly went in the river myself. "Cockroach," she said, entirely unbothered. "They fly out here. Twice the size of the normal ones, probably. I used to scream. I don't anymore. Tom taught me what to actually worry about and what's just big and ugly and harmless, and there's no venomous snakes at all here, none, so mostly you're just supposed to look and not touch."

Something dark and woolly nosed its way out of the tree line then, a black alpaca, trotting straight to her and nudging her shoulder with real affection.

"This is Toothless," she said, scratching behind its ear without looking. "He follows me most days."

The sky had gone the particular dark green-grey it goes right before it properly opens up out here, and the wind had picked up enough to bend the treetops, and Lexi looked up at it with an expression I can only describe as thrilled.

"There's a storm coming," she said, planting her feet, suddenly, gloriously serious, "and nothing can stop it but us."

And then she turned and bolted, shrieking with laughter, Toothless galloping after her in a way that should not be physically possible for an alpaca, both of them vanishing round the bend as the first real rumble of thunder rolled off the mountains behind us.

I made it back before the rain did, mostly, and spent the walk thinking about how little any of that storm actually threatens out here. The homes are built to take real weather — the earthbag walls don't so much resist a storm as absorb it, and everything runs off solar with proper battery storage besides, so a dark sky doesn't mean a dark house the way it would back home. Cisterns catch every drop of rain that falls, feed straight into the irrigation lines Nick tends, and nobody out here has ever once seen a utility bill, Jay. Not one. There's a single annual fee, less than two thousand dollars American, and even that's expected to shrink toward nothing as the community's own ventures keep growing, which they already are, month over month, faster than any of us quite expected when we started this.



THE SPIRIT HOUSE, PROPERLY

I went back up to Max that evening, once the storm had passed and the sky had cleared into something so full of stars it looked, as Lexi would say, almost too good to be real. I'd been carrying the whole day up there with me without meaning to — Karlie's grandmother and her single suitcase, Nova's whole rebuilt life, Nick's blessing he never asked for, Lexi's absolute certainty about a storm nothing could stop but us — and something in me needed to sit with the fire before the day was properly over.

Max was exactly where he always is, feeding the coals with the same unhurried patience he's fed them with, I'd guess, for longer than I've been alive. He looked up as I came in and didn't seem surprised at all.

"You've got a look about you," he said. "Like a man who's spent all day collecting other people's stories and just realised he hasn't got anywhere left to put them."

"Something like that."

"Sit, then. Let the fire hold some of it for you. That's most of what it's actually for." He fed it a length of pale wood, watched it take, and settled back.

I mentioned, sitting, that Lexi had told me he teaches some mornings — Steiner-style, whatever that properly means. He laughed, a real laugh.

"Steiner would be horrified what I've done with his ideas, honestly, but the bones hold up. Don't pour facts into a child like filling a jug. Let them build something with their hands, tell a proper story while they're doing it, and the facts stick on their own." He shrugged. "Also I teach archery Thursdays, played a bit of rugby back home, badly. Small mercies I've still got both hips."

"Go on. Ask me the real one, then. Not the smoke this time."

So I did. I asked him, properly, why here — not the poetic version I'd half-written in my head already, but the actual reason, the whole of it, if he'd give it to me.

He was quiet a long while. Long enough that I thought he might simply decline, the way he sometimes does, and let the silence be the whole answer. But he didn't.

"I'll tell you about a man named Dan Andrews," he said, "and you'll think I'm still angry about politics, and you'd be half right." He turned a piece of wood over, unhurried. "Watched a premier turn my own country into somewhere I no longer recognised. Checkpoints. Curfews. Neighbours reporting on neighbours like it was a virtue. I'm not here to argue you into agreeing with me, Anderson. I'm telling you what it did to me, which isn't the same as telling you I'm right. It made me leave. That's a fact regardless of the politics under it."

"Is that why Mexico?"

"For a while. A man named Jeff took me in — wealthy fella, Edmonton originally, enormous ranch, more money than sense. Generous, genuinely. But isolation does something to a man alone with his money and nobody to answer to, and it became clear what he wanted from me wasn't quite what he was saying out loud." Max shrugged, plainly. "I'm not gay. Told him so, kindly. He didn't love hearing it. Crikey, the drive out of there was awkward. But I left, and no real drama in the telling of it now, whatever there was in the living of it."

"And then here. I want to be honest about what 'here' did for me — it isn't magic, whatever the smoke makes you think some evenings. It's just quiet. Nobody's checkpoint. Nobody's ranch. My own fire, my own hours, my own body, entirely mine again." He looked at me directly. "I believe in autonomy the way some men believe in scripture. My body, my choice, in every direction that phrase can point. And something cruder alongside it — fool around, find out. The universe keeps its own ledger. You don't need to enforce consequences on people. Life does that for you, eventually, always."

"That's a lot of philosophy for one fire pit."

"It's a lot of years for one fire pit." He smiled, and the weight of it seemed to lift off him. "I'll tell you something funny, since we're being honest. Little place in town, run by the loveliest South Korean woman you've ever met, does sushi better than anything I had back home, and I've gone down that mountain more than I'd admit purely to sit at her counter and pretend I'm only there for the fish."

"Max."

"Don't," he said, laughing, hand up. "I've had four months of Janette giving me that exact look. A man's allowed one blind spot. Mine's apparently the whole of it."

I let that go, though I confess, Jay, I filed it away rather gleefully.

He reached over and pulled a machete from beside the hearth, held it up next to the small folding knife I keep in my pocket out of habit more than use.

"That's not a knife," he said, deadpan, and I laughed out loud, hadn't expected him of all people to know that film. "This is a knife." He turned it over, admiring it. "Every man needs a proper blade. Not for violence, mostly — for building. Carving a spoon, clearing a path, making something with your hands instead of buying it made by someone else's. And for protection too, because a peaceful man who can't defend the peace isn't peaceful, he's just unprepared." Around his neck hung a single curved crocodile tooth on a leather cord, from a hunt years back he'd rather not fully retell tonight.

"Blimey," was all I managed. "Bloody hell, mate."

"Three rules," he said, setting the machete down. "Do no harm. Treat others as you'd deserve to be treated, not as they treat you. And fool around, find out, for everything else." He smiled. "That's my religion. Everything else is decoration. Well — that, and seven virtues we try to actually build a life around here, if you want the fuller list. Truth. Beauty. Wisdom. Compassion. Freedom. Justice. Prosperity. Get those roughly right and the rest tends to sort itself."

The fire popped, smoke curling thick, and I watched shapes move through it again — a wing, maybe, or something like an eye — and Max watched me watching it.

"Jung called this archetype," he said. "The mind reaches for the same shapes no matter where it's born. Campbell

said every hero's story is secretly the same story in different clothes. McKenna thought the line between imagination and reality was thinner than most people are comfortable admitting. Ram Dass just wanted everyone quiet long enough to notice they were already home." He fed the fire again. "I don't know which had it exactly right. I know a tribe without its own myths isn't a tribe, it's just a postcode. This place has one now. You're helping write it, whether you meant to or not, with that camera of yours."

"What's the myth, then? Ours."

"That a person can start over. That the men who leave you broken don't get the last word on who you become." He looked at me a long moment. "Want to know how to inspire someone properly, for that documentary of yours? Don't show them your fire. Show them theirs."

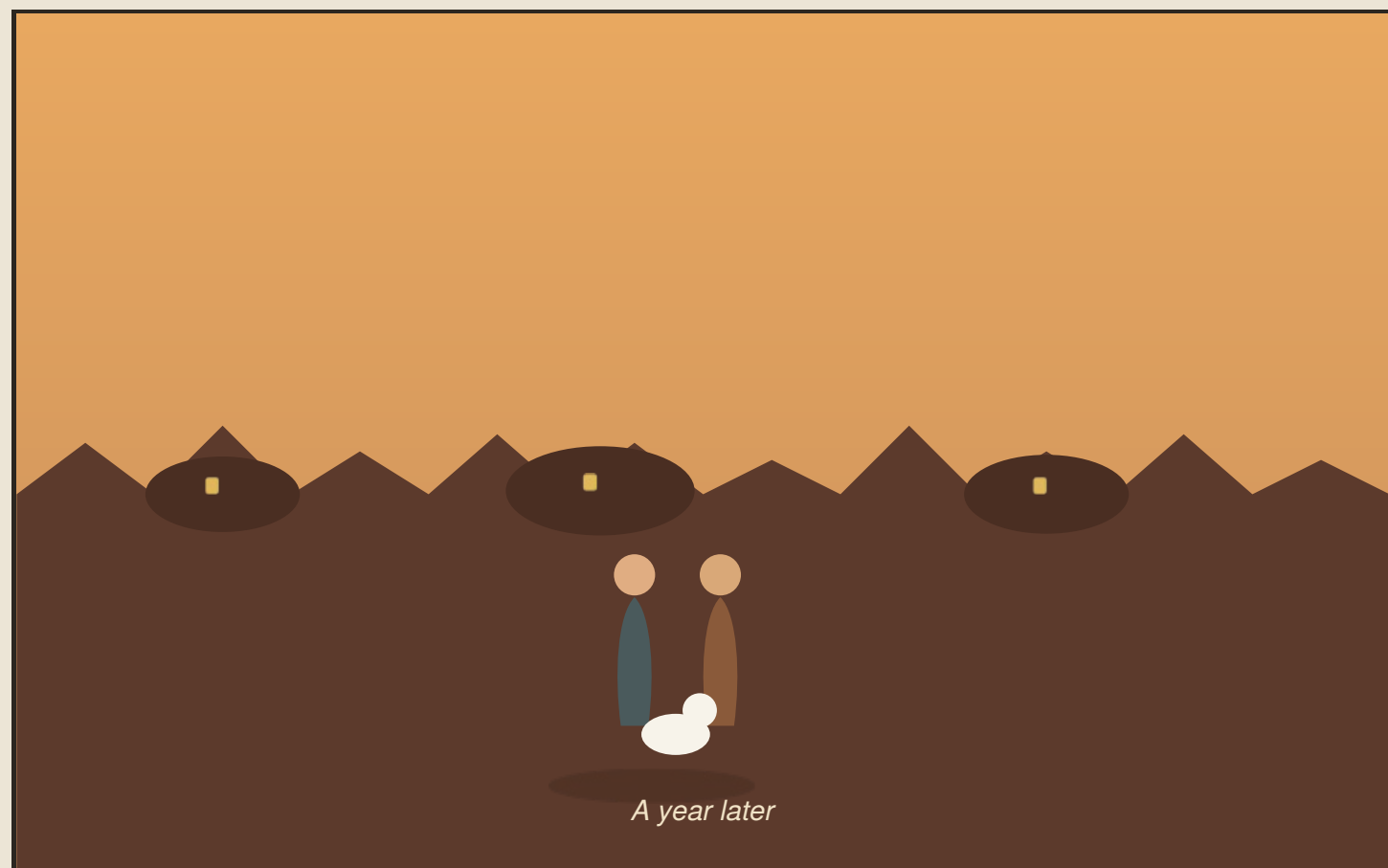
I asked him, near the end, if he was afraid of dying, up here, alone on his ridge most nights.

"Not remotely," he said. "There's a ceibo tree just past the treeline there, enormous old thing, been standing since before anyone thought to build a Spirit House beside it. I've already asked David that when my time comes, that's where I go. Roots wrapped round whatever's left of me. Feels like the correct ending, don't you think? Fire behind me, tree above me, and whoever's tending the coals by then carrying on same as I did."

He smiled, and for a moment looked lighter than I'd ever seen him.

"I do miss two things from home, properly miss, no philosophy attached," he added, almost as an afterthought. "Vegemite. And Tim Tams. If you're ever near an import shop, Anderson, I will owe you forever."

I told him I would, and I meant it, and I left the Spirit House that night in a state I'm still not entirely out of, writing to you now. Not converted to anything in particular. Just quieter inside than I've been in longer than I can properly account for. I stood a while at the treeline before heading down, looking back at the smoke against the stars, and thought about how strange it is that a fire tended by one stubborn, funny, wounded man could feel like the actual centre of somewhere, more than any office or high street or church I ever stood in back home. I don't fully understand it. I'm not sure Max does either, not the mechanism of it, only the fact of it, which he seems to have made peace with a long time before I arrived to ask him about it.



That was the day, Jay. Not ordinary at all, in the end, though it started that way, and I think that might be the whole trick of this place — every day looks ordinary right up until it isn't. I haven't even told you about the Elysian Hour yet, our own currency, pegged monthly to a coin most banks have never heard of, earned only on work planned out before you lift a finger, so nobody's ever arguing over what an hour was actually worth. I haven't told you about the council, or the vote, or the ten hours a week that's owed and not paid, because it isn't a wage, it's closer to belonging. I'll save all that. This letter's long enough, and you were always more interested in the people than the paperwork anyway.

I know you think I've traded one kind of hard life for a fantasy. I understand why it looks that way from where you're standing, with the cold coming in and the news the way it's been and every month somehow costing more than the last, drinking away another Friday in one of those grim little pubs you and I both know too well, the kind with the sticky carpet and the telly always on too loud and the same six blokes at the bar who were there the last time either of us bothered showing up. I'm not writing to convince you, salty bitch, though I rather hope it does. I'm only writing to tell you what a Tuesday looks like here, and let you decide for yourself what that's worth.

Here's the number, since you always were better with numbers than I am and I know you'll want it plainly stated rather than buried in a paragraph. My whole month, food and lodging and everything the community doesn't already provide free, comes to under four hundred dollars American, and I haven't owed anyone a single pound since the day I arrived. No card debt trailing behind me, no overdraft I'm pretending not to look at, nothing. I know what you're carrying, Jay. I've seen the letters you leave on the counter and pretend I haven't. I'm not saying that to shame you. I'm saying it because I think you've been quietly drowning in a currency this place simply doesn't ask you to spend, and I don't think you've let yourself imagine what it would feel like to put that particular weight down.

There's a business side to all this too, beyond just the living cheaply — I know you'll ask, being you. Some of what keeps this place running comes from Nova's ventures, some from digital content the community puts out under a few different names, passive income trickling in from things made once and left to keep earning quietly in the background. It's not a fortune. Nobody's getting rich. But it means the annual fee keeps shrinking year over year rather than climbing the way every bill back home seems to, and there's something in that I find genuinely moving, this idea that serving the community properly, building something useful for it, eventually feeds back and rewards the person who built it too. Nobody's keeping score exactly, and somehow the score keeps coming out even anyway.

I should say too, before I forget, there's only so many seats here, and they don't open often. Twelve of us, full now, bar whoever eventually replaces whoever eventually leaves. I'm not saying that to pressure you, Jay, I promise you that's not what this letter's for. I just think you should know it isn't the sort of place you can decide to join on a whim five years from now if this doesn't land today. Whatever you decide, decide it knowing the door doesn't stay open forever, not because anyone's guarding it, but because there's only so much mountain to go round.

We're the ones who dared live differently, Jay. All of us up here, in our own strange separate ways — a fire-tender carrying a whole philosophy in his hands, a director who makes pizza, a farm girl from Poland who thinks about her grandmother's single suitcase every single day, an artist who walked away from money to make more of it on her own terms, two men who built a life quietly and beautifully out of pipes and eggs and old runes, a woman who's certain the earth is flat and is loved exactly as much as everyone who thinks she's wrong, a nine-year-old who already understands things I'm still reaching for, and even the ones I've never spoken to, playing guitar alone in a crooked house at midnight, welcome all the same. There's a name some of us have started using for the whole idea, bigger than just this one mountain — International Common Unity, a framework, David calls it, for what human beings might manage if they were finally left alone to flourish properly, wherever on earth they happened to start from. I don't know if it'll ever be bigger than us. I know it's already changed me, quietly and completely, in ways I'm still finding new words for even as I write this last page to you.

This is the village that works for everyone, Jay, and it doesn't much care who you were before you got here. It only cares what you build once you have.

Your brother, Anderson



That was the letter, more or less word for word, the one I found again while unpacking a box last week. I wrote it almost a year ago now. Reading it back, I forgot how much I still doubted him when I first got it — how many times I read that line about the mechanic and told myself he was exaggerating, that no place actually needed someone like me.

I was wrong about that, same as I was wrong about most of it. I read that letter maybe eleven times before I finally wrote back, and nearly turned round twice at the airport, if I'm being honest with whoever eventually reads this alongside him.

I finished reading it again this evening, set it down, and walked the short way over to Anderson's place — past Karlie's garden, past the smoke still rising thin from the ridge — with grease still under my fingernails from the truck I'd spent the afternoon under. There's always something needing fixing here, same as anywhere, except here it feels like tending rather than surviving, and I think it's the first time in my adult life work has felt like the first thing instead of the second.

He was out front with Neo already, like he somehow knew I was coming, which knowing this place, he probably did.

"Evening, Grand Mechanic of the Universe," he said.

I told him to shut up and pass me a beer.



THOSE WHO DARED LIVE DIFFERENTLY



Anderson & Claude